

Psalms 149

Sing unto the Lord a New Song

Sing unto the Lord a new song, and his praise in the congregation of saints
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Praise ye the LORD. Sing unto the LORD a new song, and his praise in the congregation of saints.
- 2 Let Israel rejoice in him that made him: let the children of Zion be joyful in their King.
- 3 Let them praise his name in the dance: let them sing praises unto him with the timbrel and harp.
- 4 For the LORD taketh pleasure in his people: he will beautify the meek with salvation.
- 5 Let the saints be joyful in glory: let them sing aloud upon their beds.
- 6 Let the high praises of God be in their mouth, and a twoedged sword in their hand;
- 7 To execute vengeance upon the heathen, and punishments upon the people;
- 8 To bind their kings with chains, and their nobles with fetters of iron;
- 9 To execute upon them the judgment written: this honour have all his saints. Praise ye the LORD.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 149 pairs joyful worship—dance, timbrel, harp—with vivid language of God's people executing judgment on hostile nations, language best read as poetic anticipation of God's ultimate vindication of His covenant people rather than a literal operating manual for individual believers. Henry treats the psalm's combination of celebration and warfare imagery as characteristic of covenant confidence in a period when Israel's security and worship were closely intertwined; the New Testament redirects this expectation toward final, God-executed justice rather than human violence.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The call to sing a new song in the congregation of saints is paired with vivid, physical worship: rejoicing in the Maker, praising the name with dancing, and singing praises with timbrel and harp—worship engaging the whole body, not merely quiet reflection.

Verse 4-5

The reason for such joy is stated directly: the Lord takes pleasure in His people and beautifies the humble with salvation. Saints are pictured as joyful even in unusual settings—singing aloud even upon their beds, worship reaching into rest itself.

Verse 6-7

A shift toward militant imagery follows: high praises of God are pictured in the mouths of His people alongside a two-edged sword in their hand, executing vengeance on hostile nations and punishment on oppressive peoples—language expressing confident hope in God's ultimate justice against those set against His covenant people.

Verse 8-9

The imagery continues with binding kings in chains and nobles in fetters of iron, executing the judgment already written, concluding that this honor belongs to all God's saints. Read in light of later revelation, such language anticipates final, God-executed vindication rather than commissioning personal violence.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Joyful, physical worship and confident hope in God's ultimate justice against oppressive powers are held together in this psalm without contradiction—celebration and the expectation of vindication belong to the same covenant confidence. The psalm's warfare imagery is best understood as poetic anticipation of God's own decisive action on behalf of His people, not a mandate for personal vengeance, a distinction the rest of Scripture makes explicit.

Application for life today.

Let the psalm's physical, joyful worship—dancing, singing even 'upon their beds'—challenge any tendency to keep your own praise quiet, cautious, or purely internal. Hold onto verse 4's assurance that God takes pleasure in His people and beautifies the humble, especially if you tend to doubt your own standing before Him. Entrust any desire for justice against those who oppose you to God's own timing and method, as this psalm's imagery ultimately points toward, rather than taking matters into your own hands.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where might your own praise have become quiet or purely internal, and what would it look like to worship with the physical joy this psalm describes (vv. 1–3)?

2. How does verse 4's assurance that God delights in His people and beautifies the humble challenge any doubt you carry about your own standing before Him?

3. What situation currently tempts you toward taking justice into your own hands, and how does this psalm redirect that desire toward trusting God's own timing instead?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).